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7-Night New Orleans & Cozumel — Hosted Solo Group

*Norwegian Gem · 7 Nights from Tampa
February 5 – 12, 2027 · Hosted by Tina Maulsby*

Solo Cruisers 2027
HOSTED GROUP CRUISE!
LET THE GOOD TIMES SAIL!
NEW ORLEANS EDITION!

NCL GEM
SAILING FROM
TAMPA
FEBRUARY 5 - 12, 2027

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OVERNIGHT STAY!
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PLUS:
COZUMEL

SOLO PRICING	
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Laissez les bon temps rouler!

Norwegian Gem — the Solo Cruisers hosted group cruise flyer: 7 nights round-trip from Tampa, February 5–12, 2027, with a two-day overnight in New Orleans plus a full day in Cozumel. Flyer courtesy Maulsby Travel Co.

A Voyage Pack from **In the Wake**
Hosted by **Tina Maulsby · Maulsby Travel Co.**

Welcome

Made for the solo cruiser who has already booked this specific sailing and wants one trusted read on the week — the ship, the overnight in New Orleans, the day in Cozumel, the group's rhythm, and the one timing detail that changes everything — in one place.

This pack exists to make one specific cruise easier: the **Norwegian Gem**, sailing 7 nights round-trip from **Tampa, February 5 – 12, 2027**, with a **two-day overnight in New Orleans** and a full day in **Cozumel, Mexico**. It's a **hosted solo cruisers group cruise** organized and on-ship-hosted by **Tina Maulsby** at **Maulsby Travel Co.**

The one timing detail to understand before you go

This is the single most important thing in this pack, so it goes first: **the ship reaches New Orleans on Ash Wednesday, February 10 — the morning after Mardi Gras**. Fat Tuesday 2027 falls on February 9, which on this itinerary is a **sea day**. By the time you walk into the French Quarter on the 10th, Carnival is over: the big parades have rolled, Lent has begun, and the city is exhaling.

That is not bad news — it's just important news. What you get instead of the Carnival crush is a **calmer, more walkable New Orleans**: thinning crowds, easier tables, the French Quarter and its beignets and jazz all still there, and Ash Wednesday's own quiet character in a deeply Catholic city. What you will *not* get is a parade or Fat Tuesday itself. If you booked this imagining you'd catch Mardi Gras, adjust the expectation now, kindly, and you'll have a better trip for it. **Section 2** lays out both days ashore in full.

A note on what's first-hand here and what isn't

I haven't sailed this itinerary on this ship. Tina is the host running it, and what's framed as hers — her sailaway plan, her group meetups, her group-cruise rhythm — is from her own communications. Everything else comes from primary-source research: NCL's own published materials and FAQ, Wikipedia for ship specs, the ship's own In the

Wake profile for its venue list, the U.S. Consulate for Mexico contacts, the New Orleans tourism calendar for the Mardi Gras dates, and operator pages where excursions are quoted. If a number can't be sourced, it isn't asserted here.

Tina is both your booking agent and your on-ship host. Use tina@maulsbytravel.com or 910-528-5077 for booking questions, what's bundled with your group rate, and any pre-cruise logistics. Once aboard, she's the in-person organizer — sailaway gathering, group dinners, the daily where-are-we-meeting rhythm.

It is calm by design. There is no urgency, no upsell, no countdown timer. The site that produced this pack is independent — no cruise-line affiliations, no shore-excursion commissions, no display ads. (See our [affiliate disclosure](#).)

A note on the season: early February is the Gulf's dry, mild winter — well clear of hurricane season (June 1 – November 30). What February brings instead is cool, crisp air — genuinely cool in New Orleans (jacket weather) — and the occasional Gulf cold front that can firm up a sea-day ride. See [Section 7](#).

Includes an offline-capable Emergency Contacts section — a fillable family handoff card and the numbers tailored to this itinerary, available offline after first load via **In the Wake's** companion app. Designed to share with one trusted person ashore before sailing.

If you're sailing solo for the first time, you are not the only one in this group doing so. **Tina's solo cruising stories** are worth reading whether before, during, or after this trip.

At a Glance

Ship	Norwegian Gem (Jewel-class)
Cruise line	Norwegian Cruise Line (NCL)
Class	Jewel Class (2005–2007 quartet: Jewel 2005, Jade 2006, Pearl 2006, Gem 2007)

Specifications	93,530 GT · 965 ft / 294 m · 15 decks · 2,394 guests · 1,070 crew
Year built	2007 — delivered 1 October 2007 by Meyer Werft, Papenburg, Germany; IMO 9355733
Christening	December 18, 2007
Godmother	Cindy Cardella — a New Jersey mother chosen through NCL's public "search for a godmother," not a celebrity (a genuinely unusual christening)
Departure port	Port Tampa Bay, Tampa, Florida
Itinerary	7 nights / 8 days · Cozumel + a New Orleans overnight, round-trip from Tampa
Foreign ports	One — Cozumel, Mexico (New Orleans and Tampa are U.S.)
Audience	Solo travelers (hosted group)
Group host	Tina Maulsby, Maulsby Travel Co. — tina@maulsbytravel.com · 910-528-5077 (on-ship + booking)
Group solo rates	Inside \$2,008 · Ocean View \$2,539 · Balcony \$4,249 (per the group flyer; verify with Tina)
Dress code	NCL smart-casual — no formal nights (one optional "Norwegian's Night Out" dressier evening)
Currency aboard	US Dollar

Ports of call

The verified sequence for the February 5 – 12, 2027 sailing:

1. **Tampa, Florida** — embark Fri Feb 5 · evening sailaway
2. **Cruising at sea** — Sat Feb 6
3. **Cruising at sea** — Sun Feb 7
4. **Cozumel, Mexico** — Mon Feb 8 (~7 AM – 5 PM)

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5. **Cruising at sea** — Tue Feb 9 (*Mardi Gras / Fat Tuesday — spent at sea*)
 6. **New Orleans, Louisiana** — Wed Feb 10 (arrive ~8 AM, **overnight in port**) (*Ash Wednesday*)
 7. **New Orleans, Louisiana** — Thu Feb 11 (depart ~3 PM)
 8. **Tampa, Florida** — disembark Fri Feb 12

Verify your specific times in the NCL app. Track the ship's real position any time from the **Ship Tracker**.

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Section 1 — Your Ship: Norwegian Gem

A Jewel-class ship with an unusually human christening

Norwegian Gem is a **Jewel-class ship** — 93,530 gross tons, 965 feet, 15 decks, 2,394 guests, and 1,070 crew. She was **delivered on October 1, 2007** by Meyer Werft at Papenburg, Germany, the last of NCL's four-ship Jewel quartet (Jewel, Jade, Pearl, Gem). By your February 2027 sailing she's a thoroughly settled ship: mid-size by today's standards, easy to learn, and carrying nearly two decades of crew rhythm.

Her christening is worth knowing about, because it's genuinely unusual. Instead of a pop star or an actress, the Gem's **godmother is Cindy Cardella — a mother from New Jersey**, chosen through a public "search for a godmother" NCL ran before the December 18, 2007 naming. It's a small thing, but it fits a ship that has always been a workaday favorite rather than a headline-grabber. If you like the idea that the person who blessed your ship's maiden season was somebody's mom from Jersey, you're in good company.

For a side-by-side sense of the Gem's scale against the newer megaships — she's roughly two-thirds the tonnage of NCL's own Prima — the **Ship Size Atlas** shows the real proportions. Smaller has real advantages: the Gem loads and unloads faster, the walk from anywhere to anywhere is shorter, and she rarely feels as corridor-crowded as a 4,000-guest ship on a sea day. For where NCL and the other lines are pointing their newest Caribbean hardware, **Caribbean Cruise Trends 2026** is the wider context.

Dining

The Gem's dining map, confirmed against her current **In the Wake ship profile**:

Included with your fare (no extra charge):

- **Grand Pacific** — the main dining room; multi-course, no cover charge. Tina's standing group dinner usually anchors here or at Magenta.
- **Magenta** — the second main dining room; smaller and cozier than Grand Pacific, same included menu.
- **Garden Café** — the buffet; long hours, and the reliable fallback at any time of day.

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- **O'Sheehan's** — the pub, open essentially around the clock; wings, burgers, and comfort food when nothing else is serving. The solo cruiser's best friend at odd hours.

Specialty dining (extra charge, or via a Specialty Dining Package):

- **Cagney's Steakhouse** — NCL's reliable steakhouse.
- **Le Bistro** — French; the most romantic room on the ship, and a fine solo-treat night.
- **La Cucina** — Italian.
- **Teppanyaki** — Japanese hibachi, cooked at your table; the showy, social room where solo diners are seated with others by design.
- **Moderno Churrascaria** — Brazilian rodizio; the gaucho-carved-meats experience.
- **Orchid Garden** — Asian Fusion, complimentary; the adjacent Sushi Bar and Sake Bar are à la carte.

Teppanyaki is the smart solo-dining pick on the Gem: the communal-table format means you'll eat with a small group whether you booked alone or not, which takes the "table for one" question off the table entirely.

Drinks. NCL's Premium Beverage Package is commonly bundled into the "**Free at Sea**" promotion at booking. If your group fare included Free at Sea, drinks may already be covered — **verify what's bundled with Tina**. Bought separately, the package runs on the order of \$100+/day per person plus 20% gratuity, and breaks even at roughly 5–6 drinks a day. Put your real pattern into the **drink-calculator** before you decide; the companion article **Is the drink package worth it?** walks the math with worked examples.

The Day 1 mistake to avoid: don't buy an unlimited drink package at the front desk on embarkation afternoon on impulse. Decide before you board, ideally as part of your Free at Sea bundle. Mid-sail upgrades cost more per day and give you fewer days of use.

Cabin categories — the solo calculus

The group flyer shows three solo tiers: **Inside \$2,008 · Ocean View \$2,539 · Balcony \$4,249**. Reading them:

- **Inside at \$2,008** — the price-leader, windowless. On an itinerary this port-heavy in feel — two sea days, a full Cozumel day, and two days docked in a walkable city — you'll spend little waking time in the cabin. If budget is the deciding factor, Inside is the honest choice, and the **stateroom sanity check** will tell you in four questions whether a windowless room will bother you.
- **Ocean View at \$2,539** — a real window and daylight for a \$531 step up. The middle path.
- **Balcony at \$4,249** — a private outdoor space. Note the jump: on this sailing the balcony is **\$1,710 over Ocean View** (just over \$1,700), a much steeper differential than on most cruises. A Caribbean balcony earns its keep on warm sea mornings, but two of your best days are docked in cool-weather New Orleans where a balcony matters less. Weigh that gap honestly against what else \$1,700 buys on this trip.

Verify what's in each tier with Tina — Free at Sea inclusions (drinks, Wi-Fi, specialty dining, excursion credit) sometimes vary by cabin category, and that can change the real value comparison more than the sticker prices do. Once you've chosen, the **cabin organization guide** covers the small-space pragmatics.

Connectivity at sea

NCL Wi-Fi is tier-based (basic browsing / streaming / streaming + voice) and frequently bundled into Free at Sea. The **internet at sea guide** covers the cross-line baselines and how to avoid cellular roaming charges in port. A convenience of this itinerary: two of your three port stops (New Orleans, Tampa) are on U.S. cellular — your regular phone plan works ashore with no roaming, so you can lean on port-day signal and keep the daily one-line message to your contact ashore cheap and easy. See **Section 6**.

Section 2 — Day by Day

The sequence below is the ship's verified itinerary. **Verify your specific times in the NCL app.** Build each port day in the **Port Day Planner** before you go ashore, and record what actually happened in the **Port Logbook** on the way back.

Day 1 — Friday, February 5 — Tampa (embarkation)



Port Tampa Bay and the Tampa waterfront — embarkation day for the Norwegian Gem

Terminal: Port Tampa Bay cruise terminal (confirm your specific terminal in the NCL app before sailing).

Getting to the port:

- **Tampa International (TPA) → Port Tampa Bay:** about 20 minutes; rideshare typically \$20–35.
- **If driving:** the port's cruise terminals have paid parking (reserve ahead in peak weeks).
- **Embark window:** typically early afternoon; watch your assigned check-in time. The Gem sails in the **evening** down Tampa Bay.

Pre-cruise hotel — recommended. Fly into Tampa the day before (Thursday Feb 4) and stay near the waterfront or downtown so a flight slip doesn't threaten your evening sailaway. Confirm Tina's pre-cruise meetup plans before you book. The **Tampa port page** covers the Riverwalk and Ybor City if you build in an extra day.

The realistic Day 1 timeline:

- **Check-in** at your assigned window; complete NCL online check-in in advance to skip a queue.
- **Aboard:** drop carry-ons, find lunch at the Garden Café buffet or O'Sheehan's while cabins are readied.
- **Cabin ready:** meet your steward; drop bags.
- **Muster drill:** NCL's is partly app-based (watch the safety video in the NCL app) plus an in-person check-in at your station.
- **Evening sailaway:** Tina's group gathers before departure — watch her communications for the exact spot. A Tampa departure runs down the bay past the channel markers; a mellow start.
- **Dinner:** join the group's first dinner if Tina has set one, or eat casual. This is the night to find the Solo Cruisers meetup and put faces to names.

What to pack in your carry-on for Day 1: a light layer *and* something warmer for cool evenings, swimsuit (pools open before checked bags arrive), **all medications**, a change of clothes, your **travel documents** (see the passport note below), phone charger, refillable water bottle. Checked bags may not reach your cabin until evening. For a fuller walk-through, **Embarkation Day: What to Expect** is the primer.

Documents — the closed-loop rule. This is a **closed-loop cruise** (round-trip from the same U.S. port) that visits only one foreign country, Mexico (Cozumel). Under U.S. rules, citizens on a closed-loop cruise may sail with a **birth certificate plus a government photo ID** instead of a passport. **A passport is still strongly preferred**, though — if a medical or family emergency forced you to fly home from Cozumel, you'd need one. Bring the passport if you have it.

Money/card: your NCL keycard is your ID, room key, and onboard charge account.
Currency aboard: US Dollar.

Day 2 — Saturday, February 6 — Cruising at sea

The settling-in day, heading south across the Gulf toward the Yucatán Channel.

- **Morning:** breakfast at the Garden Café or a sit-down at Grand Pacific; find your spot. Sea-day mornings are when the spa's thermal-suite introductory rates appear.

- **Midday:** the pool deck (weather permitting — early February can be breezy), a port talk for Cozumel, trivia, or live music.
- **Evening:** the group's dinner if Tina has set one; a production show in the Gem's theater; the Bliss Ultra Lounge or Spinnaker Lounge after.

This is the day the group forms. Teppanyaki, if you book it, is the easiest first solo-dining night — you're seated with others by design.

Day 3 — Sunday, February 7 — Cruising at sea

Second sea day, crossing toward Cozumel. By now the rhythm is familiar.

- **Morning:** Ocean-view breakfast; spa thermal suite if you skipped Day 2.
- **Afternoon:** pool deck at the quiet hours (2–4 PM), the casino, or an indoor diversion if a front has the wind up.
- **Evening:** group dinner; a specialty night at Le Bistro or Cagney's if you want to treat yourself; the theater.

Day 4 — Monday, February 8 — Cozumel, Mexico



Cozumel's coastal road and the reef offshore — the Western Caribbean's signature snorkel destination

Arrival: ~7 AM. **Depart:** ~5 PM. Ships dock at one of three piers — **Punta Langosta** (downtown), the **International Pier**, or **Puerta Maya**. Check the NCL app. Cozumel is the most heavily visited Caribbean port; expect several ships in port the same day.

Cozumel — the underwater destination of the Western Caribbean. The reef off Cozumel — protected within **Cozumel Reefs National Park since 1996** — delivers visibility consistently among the best in the Caribbean, and February's dry-season clarity is the best of the year. If anyone in the group has ever wanted to try snorkeling, **this is the day for it** — and, on this itinerary, your only warm-water port day, so make it count.

Easy-day option (no excursion):

- Stay near your pier. **Punta Langosta** puts you directly in downtown San Miguel — walk around, find a real Mexican lunch (\$15–25 at a non-tourist restaurant), and shop the **Mercado Municipal** (the local market, not the pier tourist shops). The International and Puerta Maya piers are a ~\$10 taxi from downtown.

Half-day options:

- **Chankanaab Beach Adventure Park** (~\$50 entry, ~15 min by taxi) — calm water, easy reef snorkeling, loungers; the family-friendly, low-effort choice.
- **Paradise Beach** (small entry with a food/drink minimum, ~15 min by taxi) — a lower-key beach-club day.

Full-day options:

- **Palancar Reef snorkel tour** — *the iconic Cozumel trip*. Pier operators run it for \$40–60/person (ship excursion \$80–110); a two-hour tour in calm, fish-heavy water. **The trip that converts non-snorkelers.** Bring an underwater camera — the **cruise-tech and photography guide** covers waterproof cases and mounts if you want to think it through before packing.
- **Tulum ruins** (ferry + bus; \$90–150 ship or ~\$80 independent) — a long day; even in February the midday sun is strong, so pace it.

A note on the 5 PM departure: it's an earlier all-aboard than many Cozumel calls, so don't book a tour that cuts the return close. Confirm your all-aboard time and be at the pier 30–45 minutes ahead.

For wheelchair users and limited mobility: Cozumel's piers are accessible; Punta Langosta connects to a paved boardwalk into San Miguel. Many beach clubs offer beach wheelchairs — ask ahead. Snorkel *boats* are typically not accessible; book a beach-snorkel instead. The **disability-at-sea guide** covers the broader picture.

Pack for Cozumel: swimsuit, reef-safe sunscreen (locally enforced), water shoes, sun hat, \$60–80 USD cash, and a small underwater camera. Worth a look: the **Cozumel port page**, its **gallery**, and the **Cozumel logbook**.

Day 5 — Tuesday, February 9 — Cruising at sea (*Mardi Gras / Fat Tuesday*)

Northwest across the Gulf toward the Mississippi delta. **Today is Fat Tuesday** — Mardi Gras itself — and you're spending it at sea. That's the itinerary's one irony: you cross the Gulf on the day New Orleans throws its biggest party, and dock the morning after. Nothing to do about it but enjoy a calm day and set your expectations for tomorrow (see below).

- **Morning:** a slow breakfast; the spa; pack a mental list for two days in New Orleans.
- **Afternoon:** the New Orleans port talk — worth attending, because a well-run one will tell you what's open and what's winding down post-Carnival.
- **Evening:** the group dinner; maybe the ship marks Fat Tuesday with a bit of its own Carnival theming — check the daily program.

Day 6 — Wednesday, February 10 — New Orleans (overnight)



New Orleans — the French Quarter, Jackson Square, and the Mississippi riverfront

Arrival: ~8 AM, up the Mississippi River — a slow, worth-being-on-deck-for approach past the delta and the working river. **The ship stays overnight**, so you have all of today, tonight, and tomorrow morning in the city. Docking is at the **Port of New Orleans** (Julia Street or Erato Street terminal), an easy walk or short streetcar ride from the French Quarter.

Today is Ash Wednesday — the day after Mardi Gras. Here is the honest picture: the parades are done, Bourbon Street is being hosed down, and the city is shifting from Carnival to Lent. In practice that means **thinner crowds, easier restaurant tables, and a calmer French Quarter than the postcards** — a genuinely pleasant way to experience New Orleans if you're not chasing a parade. Some bars and music clubs run reduced hours the day after Fat Tuesday as the city recovers; the core tourist landmarks stay open.

Free or low-cost, walkable:

- **Café du Monde** at the French Market — the original, open around the clock, famous for beignets and café au lait. Cash-friendly, always a line, worth it.
- **Jackson Square + St. Louis Cathedral** — the heart of the French Quarter. On Ash Wednesday the Cathedral holds Mass and distributes ashes; even as a visitor it's a quiet, moving thing to witness in a Catholic city on the first day of Lent.

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- **The French Quarter** on foot — Royal Street (galleries, antiques, quieter than Bourbon), the French Market, the riverfront Moon Walk promenade.
 - **Frenchmen Street** — the *locals'* live-music street, a few blocks northeast of the Quarter, and the better bet than Bourbon for real jazz. Some clubs may open later post-Carnival; ask at the port or check listings.

Paid / ticketed:

- **The National WWII Museum** — consistently rated among the best museums in the country; a half-day minimum if you do it properly. The single strongest indoor choice if the weather is cool and gray.
- **St. Charles Avenue streetcar** to the **Garden District** — the historic olive-green streetcar (a modest fare, exact change or a Jazzy Pass) rolls under live oaks past antebellum mansions. Combine with a walk down Magazine Street for shops and lunch.
- **Swamp / bayou tour** — airboat or pontoon into the wetlands beyond the city; a half-day, usually with hotel/port pickup.

Because you're overnight, split it: do the outdoor Quarter, Café du Monde, and a leisurely lunch today; save the WWII Museum or the Garden District for tomorrow morning. Or reverse it around the weather. The overnight is the whole gift of this itinerary — you don't have to cram.

Tonight: the ship is your hotel, but the city is open. A quiet dinner in the Quarter, live jazz on Frenchmen if the clubs are running, and a walk back to the ship along the riverfront is close to a perfect New Orleans evening. Tina may organize a group dinner ashore — watch her communications.

Pack for the day: comfortable walking shoes (the Quarter is flagstone and uneven), a **warm layer and a light rain jacket** (February NOLA runs cool — highs in the low 60s, evenings in the 40s), cash for Café du Monde and street musicians, and your phone on U.S. cellular (no roaming). Worth a look before you go: the **New Orleans port page**, its **gallery**, and the **New Orleans logbook**.

Day 7 — Thursday, February 11 — New Orleans (departure day)



The Garden District and St. Charles Avenue — antebellum mansions under live oaks, reached by the historic streetcar

A second morning ashore, then the ship departs ~3 PM back down the Mississippi. Confirm the exact all-aboard time — it will be early afternoon — and don't stray far after late morning.

How to use the morning:

- Whatever you saved from yesterday — **the National WWII Museum** if you didn't get there, the **Garden District streetcar** loop, or a **swamp tour** if it fits before all-aboard (confirm the return time against the ship's departure — this is the day a long tour can go wrong).
- **Magazine Street** for shopping and a last real New Orleans lunch — po'boys, gumbo, muffuletta.
- **One more Café du Monde** before you board. It's tradition now.

Be back onboard by the early-afternoon all-aboard, then take the Mississippi sailaway from deck — the river passage out is as good as the one in.

Day 8 — Friday, February 12 — Tampa (debarkation)

Arrival: ~7 AM at Port Tampa Bay.

The realistic timeline:

- **Early breakfast** at the Garden Café or O'Sheehan's.
- **Self-disembarkation** begins after the ship clears; walk-off proceeds in waves, and all guests are typically off by mid-morning.

The bag situation. The night before, place tagged checked luggage outside your cabin door by the posted deadline; bags go ashore overnight and you collect them in the terminal before customs. Keep a change of clothes, all medications, documents, and valuables in your carry-on.

Getting from Port Tampa Bay to TPA: rideshare/taxi ~20 minutes, \$20–35. If you have hours before an afternoon flight, the **Tampa Riverwalk**, Ybor City, or the Florida Aquarium near the port are easy fills.

Section 3 — Pre-Cruise Countdown

Work the **countdown page** alongside this list if you like a running checklist.

6+ months before — booking and big decisions

- **Confirm the booking with Tina.** Cabin category, final price, and exactly what's in the group rate (Free at Sea — drinks tier, Wi-Fi minutes, specialty dining credits, excursion credit, gratuities).
- **Buy travel insurance.** Sensible for any cruise; February is outside hurricane season, so this is standard trip-interruption/medical coverage.
- **Plan flights to Tampa (TPA).** Arrive at minimum the day before sailing (Thursday Feb 4, 2027).

4 months before — soft logistics

- **NCL online check-in** in the NCL app; complete the health questions close to sailing.

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- **Specialty dining reservations.** NCL opens these a few months out — **Le Bistro and Teppanyaki fill first.** If you want just one specialty meal, book it for a sea day (Day 2 or 3) when the ship rhythm has settled.
 - **Excursions.** Book the Cozumel snorkel/beach tour and any New Orleans tour (WWII Museum timed tickets, swamp tour) in advance; New Orleans museum tickets especially can sell for popular slots.

2 months before — final commitments

- **Confirm gratuities** — whether pre-paid in your group rate or billed aboard (see Section 5).
- **Drink / Wi-Fi packages** if Free at Sea didn't include the tier you want — decide with the **drink-calculator**, don't impulse-buy aboard.
- **Confirm pre-cruise hotel** and begin the **packing list**. The site's **packing-lists** hub has printable versions.

1 month before — final prep window

- **Photocopy your passport / birth certificate** — keep the copy in your cabin, separate from the original.
- **Print the emergency handoff card** and share it with one trusted person ashore.
- **Confirm Tina's group rhythm** — sailaway gathering spot and time, Day 1 dinner plan, whether she's organizing a New Orleans group dinner.

14 days before

- **NCL online check-in closes** ahead of sailing — complete it early.
- **Save boarding documents** offline in the NCL app.
- **Begin physical packing** — remember this trip needs *both* beachwear and a real winter layer.

Day before — Tampa arrival

- **Fly into TPA Thursday Feb 4.**
- **Check into your hotel;** confirm Friday-morning porter/rideshare timing.

Section 4 — Packing List (calibrated for a two-climate February sailing)

This is the packing section to read carefully, because **this itinerary spans two climates**. You need warm-water beachwear for Cozumel *and* a genuine cool-weather kit for New Orleans, where early-February highs sit in the low 60s and evenings drop into the 40s. Pack for both.

- **Tampa embarkation / debarkation:** mild, breezy (55–72°F).
- **Two Gulf sea days:** cool-to-mild, occasionally breezy.
- **Cozumel:** warm and dry (~80°F day, water ~79°F).
- **New Orleans (two days):** cool and crisp — highs low 60s, evenings 40s, chance of rain.
- **Dress culture:** NCL smart-casual; no formal nights.

Documents and money

- **Passport** (strongly preferred) *or* **birth certificate + government photo ID** (acceptable for this closed-loop cruise — see **Section 2**)
- Photocopy of your travel document (separate location)
- Travel insurance policy + emergency phone number (printed)
- Credit card + debit card (separate locations)
- **\$200–300 USD cash** in small bills — Café du Monde and street musicians in New Orleans are cash-friendly; plus Cozumel tips and taxis
- NCL boarding documents (saved offline in the NCL app)
- Group itinerary from Tina

Carry-on (must arrive on the ship with you)

- All medications in original prescription bottles
- Phone + charger + power bank

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- Refillable water bottle
 - **A warm layer** (New Orleans evenings; ship AC) *and* a light rain jacket
 - Swimsuit (pools open before checked bags arrive)
 - Change of clothes (in case a checked bag is delayed)
 - Sunglasses, sun hat, reef-safe sunscreen (enforced in Cozumel)

Daytime — warm (Cozumel + pool)

- 2–3 swimsuits
- 1–2 swim cover-ups
- 2–3 quick-dry t-shirts / tank tops
- 1–2 pairs lightweight shorts
- Water shoes (Cozumel reef)

Daytime — cool (New Orleans, sea days, Tampa)

- **1 warm jacket or heavy sweater** (low-40s NOLA evenings)
- 2–3 long-sleeve shirts / light sweaters (layering)
- 1–2 pairs long pants / jeans (New Orleans walking, cool evenings)
- **A light rain jacket or packable umbrella** (February NOLA rain is common)
- **Genuinely comfortable walking shoes** — the French Quarter is flagstone and uneven; you'll log real miles over two days

Evening — ship dining

- **4–5 smart-casual outfits** — NCL's evening code is American smart casual
- **1 dressier outfit** for "Norwegian's Night Out" or a specialty night (no formalwear needed)
- Comfortable shoes for carpeted corridors

Toiletries

- All prescription medications (original bottles, carry-on)

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- OTC standbys: Tylenol, Advil, Imodium, Benadryl, **Bonine or Dramamine** (**Section 7**)
 - Reef-safe sunscreen (SPF 30+; enforced in Cozumel)
 - After-sun aloe; lip balm with SPF
 - Toothbrush, toothpaste, deodorant, basics

Accessories and essentials

- Polarized sunglasses; brimmed sun hat (Cozumel)
- Small daypack for port days
- **Waterproof phone case** (Cozumel snorkel; NOLA rain)
- Small dry bag (~5L) for the beach day
- Power adapter (US outlets aboard; standard US plugs fine)
- Pen + small notebook if you keep a logbook

Skip — what NOT to bring

- **Iron or steamer** — prohibited in cabins; the ship provides facilities
 - **Candles** — prohibited (fire hazard)
 - **Heavy jewelry** — leave high-value pieces home
 - **Formalwear** — no formal nights on NCL
 - **A parade costume** — you'll be at sea for Fat Tuesday; the parades are over by the time you dock
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Section 5 — Budget Breakdown

The numbers below are calibrated for this specific sailing. For a total tuned to your own cabin, drinking habits, excursion appetite, and tipping pattern, the **cruise-budget-calculator** builds a personalized figure — usually within about 5% of what you'll actually spend if you input honestly.

What's included in your fare

The group rate covers:

- Your cabin (Inside, Ocean View, or Balcony per the flyer)
- All meals at Grand Pacific, Magenta, the Garden Café, and O'Sheehan's
- Soft drinks, juice, coffee, tea at most venues
- Onboard entertainment in the theater, Spinnaker Lounge, and Bliss Ultra Lounge
- Pools, hot tubs, fitness center
- Cabin steward and dining-room service
- **If your group rate has Free at Sea attached:** likely includes the Premium Beverage Package, Wi-Fi minutes, specialty dining credits (typically 2–4 meals), and shore-excursion credit. **Verify with Tina.**

What's NOT included

Category	Typical cost (per person, week)
Auto-gratuity (if not pre-paid)	~\$140 — \$20/person/day × 7 (Inside/OV/Balcony); \$25/day Haven/Suites
Drinks package (if not in Free at Sea)	\$700+ at pre-cruise rates (~\$100/day × 7 + 20% gratuity)
Wi-Fi package (if not in Free at Sea)	\$120–280 — varies by tier
Specialty dining (beyond Free at Sea credits)	\$0–250 — Cagney's, Le Bistro, Teppanyaki, Moderno per meal
Cozumel excursion	\$0–120 — Palancar snorkel ~\$50 indep / ~\$95 ship; Chankanaab ~\$50; Tulum ~\$120
New Orleans — WWII Museum	~\$35 entry (more for exhibits/films)
New Orleans — streetcar / Garden District	~\$3–10 (streetcar fare / day pass)
New Orleans — swamp tour	\$60–100
New Orleans — food & music	as you go — beignets are a few dollars; a good dinner \$30–60

Category	Typical cost (per person, week)
Spa treatments	\$0–400 — massages \$130–200; thermal day pass ~\$40
Travel insurance	\$70–160 per person (standard, non-storm-season)
Pre-cruise hotel (Tampa)	~\$120–200
Airport transfers TPA ↔ port	~\$40–70 round trip

A realistic mid-range solo budget (per person, on top of cruise fare)

Item	Cost
Auto-gratuity (\$20 × 7)	\$140
Wi-Fi (if not bundled)	\$120
Drinks (if not bundled — moderate drinker)	\$400
Specialty dining (one Le Bistro or Teppanyaki night)	\$55
Cozumel: Palancar snorkel + lunch	\$80
New Orleans: WWII Museum + two lunches + beignets	\$90
New Orleans: streetcar + a swamp tour	\$80
Travel insurance	\$100
Pre-cruise hotel (Tampa)	\$150
Airport transfers	\$60
Total above fare	~\$1,275

Frugal version (Free at Sea bundles drinks + Wi-Fi, walk New Orleans on foot, beignets-and-po'boys eating, beach day in Cozumel): **~\$450 above fare.**

Splurge version (balcony already booked, spa days, private New Orleans tours, the full drink package): **\$1,800–3,000 above fare.**

The **cruise-tipping-calculator** covers the gratuity math; **Cruise Tipping 2026** explains how the major lines' 2026 gratuities compare.

Section 6 — Emergency Contacts

Every Voyage Pack ships with this section. Fill in the handoff card and share it with one trusted person ashore.

The family handoff card

FAMILY HANDOFF – IN THE WAKE VOYAGE PACK

CRUISER: _____
CABIN: _____
SHIP: Norwegian Gem
LINE: Norwegian Cruise Line (NCL)
SAILING: February 5 – 12, 2027
FROM: Port Tampa Bay, Tampa, Florida, USA
ITINERARY: Tampa → Cozumel (Mexico) →
New Orleans (overnight) → Tampa
GROUP HOST: Tina Maulsby, Maulsby Travel Co.
tina@maulsbytravel.com · 910-528-5077

EMERGENCY (24/7) – US State Dept, Overseas
Citizens Services (can locate the ship and
contact NCL through official channels):
+1 (888) 407-4747 (US/Canada)
+1 (202) 501-4444 (from abroad)

SHIP-TO-SHORE (non-emergency messages only):
NCL paid ship-phone relay: +1 (888) 627-4477
(credit card required; per-minute rate)

NEAREST CONSULATE BY PORT:
Tampa, FL – US domestic; call 911
New Orleans, LA – US domestic; call 911
Cozumel, Mexico – US Consulate Mérida
(US Citizen Services for the
Yucatán / Quintana Roo):
+1 (844) 528-6611 (from US)
or 999 689-0660 (local)

CRUISER MEDICAL:
Allergies: _____
Medications: _____
Conditions: _____
Insurance: _____ policy: _____

MOST RECENT KNOWN POSITION:
Track at: /tools/ship-tracker.html
or marinetraffic.com
(search "Norwegian Gem")

What an at-home contact does

If they don't hear from you for 36+ hours:

1. **Don't panic.** Cruise Wi-Fi is unreliable; silence usually means signal, not emergency. (On this itinerary, two of three ports are on U.S. cell service, so you should be reachable ashore in New Orleans and Tampa.)
2. **For a true emergency, call the State Department's Overseas Citizens Services line** (above) — they can locate the ship and reach NCL through official channels at no cost. For a non-urgent message, NCL's paid ship-phone relay connects to the onboard phone system.
3. **Reach Tina** at tina@maulsbytravel.com or 910-528-5077 — she's both your booking agent and your on-ship host.
4. **If there's been an incident:** US Coast Guard for US waters; US Consulate Mérida / Cancún Consular Agency for Mexico; ship's medical for health emergencies.
5. **Track the ship's position** at </tools/ship-tracker.html>.

What you should pack for emergencies

- Printed list of medications, allergies, and emergency contacts (in your cabin)
 - Photocopy of your passport / birth certificate (separate from the original)
 - Travel insurance policy number (printed)
 - This handoff card, in your phone's notes app and shared with one trusted person ashore
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Section 7 — Seasickness + Winter Gulf Weather

The reassuring part first: early February is well outside hurricane season (June 1 – November 30). This is a calm-water time of year in the Gulf.

What February weather actually does

- **Cozumel** is warm and dry — around 80°F, low humidity, the clearest reef water of the year.
- **The Gulf can send a cold front south** — a “norther.” When one passes, temperatures drop, the wind picks up, and a sea-day crossing gets a firmer ride and some swell. It’s a comfort question, not a safety one, and usually clears within a day.
- **New Orleans and Tampa** are cool in early February — genuinely jacket weather in New Orleans (see **Section 4**).
- **The Mississippi River approach** to New Orleans (Day 6 morning) is flat, calm river-sailing — no motion at all, and a beautiful slow entrance worth being on deck for.

Seasickness onboard

Most of this week is calm. The motion to watch for is the **Gulf crossings** (Days 2–3 outbound, Day 5 up to the delta), especially if a front is passing. A Jewel-class ship like the Gem is steady in normal winter conditions.

If you’re prone to motion sickness:

- **Bonine (meclizine)** — once-daily, less drowsy than Dramamine.
- **Sea-Bands (acupressure wristbands)** — many find them effective.
- **Ginger** (capsules, tea, candies) — mild but real.
- **Scopolamine patches** (prescription, behind-the-ear) — the strongest option; 3-day duration.
- **Stay mid-ship and low** in your cabin choice — mid-ship, lower-to-middle decks feel the least motion.

The article **Cruise Seasickness: What Actually Works** goes deeper, including the timing that matters most (start remedies *before* you feel it, not after).

If a front changes the Cozumel day

A winter front rarely cancels a Cozumel call, but a rough morning is possible. If a port is skipped for weather, NCL typically refunds prepaid *ship-sold* excursions for that port to your onboard account; independent-operator bookings are between you and the operator, and not all are weather-refundable — screenshot every independent confirmation before you sail. The New Orleans overnight is a river-dock call and far less weather-exposed.

Section 8 — Practical Logistics

Cell service and roaming

- **At sea** — ship Wi-Fi only; keep airplane mode ON. Cellular via the ship's onboard tower roams at a steep per-minute rate.
- **Cozumel, Mexico** — Telcel and AT&T Mexico; US T-Mobile often includes Mexico roaming, Verizon/AT&T-US sell ~\$10/day passes. This is your one foreign port for roaming purposes.
- **New Orleans and Tampa** — **your regular U.S. plan, no roaming.** Full signal ashore both days in New Orleans and on debarkation morning in Tampa.

The **internet at sea guide** has the cross-line detail.

Currency

- **Aboard:** US Dollar.
- **Cozumel, Mexico:** USD accepted at tourist-facing businesses; the Mexican peso (MXN) gets better prices off the tourist track. Cards at sit-downs; ATMs at the pier carry a fee.
- **New Orleans and Tampa:** US Dollar, cards everywhere — but **carry cash for New Orleans.** Café du Monde, street musicians, and some small Quarter spots are cash-friendly or cash-first.

Tipping ashore

- **Cozumel:** 10–15% on restaurant bills; 10–20 pesos for taxi drivers; \$5–10/person for half-day tours.
- **New Orleans:** standard U.S. tipping — 18–20% on restaurant bills, a few dollars per drink, and **tip the street musicians** on Royal and Frenchmen; they're playing for it. Tip swamp-tour and streetcar-tour guides \$5–10.

Onboard tipping

NCL's daily service charge for bookings made on or after January 1, 2023 is **\$20 per person, per day** for standard cabins (Club Balcony Suite and below — which covers Inside, Ocean View, and Balcony on this sailing) and **\$25 per person, per day** for The Haven and Suites. **Verify with Tina whether your group rate has it pre-paid.** Note that NCL adds a 20% gratuity automatically to beverages, specialty dining, and spa services. Extra cash for standout service is appreciated but not expected:

- Stateroom attendant: \$20–40 cash at the end of the week
- A bartender who remembers your order: \$1–2 per drink in cash

The **cruise-tipping-calculator** runs the total; **Cruise Tipping 2026** is the broader 2026 context.

Section 9 — The Group Cruise Rhythm

Tina is both your booking agent and your on-ship host. She sets the rhythm. The typical pattern:

- **Day 1 sailaway** — Tina hosts a gathering before the evening departure. Watch her communications for the exact spot and time.
- **A standing group dinner** — Tina usually anchors the group with a nightly dinner (often at Grand Pacific or Magenta) so people can find each other. Show up to whichever nights work; it's free with your fare, no per-night reservation.

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- **The New Orleans overnight** — a natural night for a group dinner *ashore* if Tina organizes one. Watch for it; a shared table in the Quarter is a good memory.
 - **Group activities** — she may add a specialty dinner, hosted trivia, or a spa day; check her communications.
 - **Port days** — most hosted groups don't require a port-day group activity; you're on your own schedule unless a specific excursion is being organized.
 - **Last-night dinner** — the Thursday-night gathering (after the second New Orleans day) is the traditional send-off.

How to find Tina on Day 1. Watch her email or Facebook for the sailaway spot and time. If you don't see anything before boarding, the pool deck or the atrium bar near sailaway is the likeliest place to find the group.

How the group actually works — the unwritten part

The schedule above is the written part. The unwritten part is what most first-time hosted-group cruisers actually wonder about, so here it is plainly:

- **Every event is opt-in, and opting out costs you nothing.** Skip tomorrow's dinner because you'd rather eat alone at O'Sheehan's with a book? Nobody logs it. The standing dinner exists so the group can find each other at a predictable time — not so attendance can be taken.
- **"No thanks, I'm doing my own thing today" is a complete sentence.** On a solo group cruise specifically, everyone aboard has needed alone-time — they recognize it and don't take it personally. Tina won't either. This matters especially in New Orleans, where you might want a whole day to wander alone.
- **Dinner-table norms.** Sit anywhere the group is sitting; no fixed seating, no group menu. On nights you skip the group, O'Sheehan's and the Garden Café make solo dining low-friction, and Teppanyaki seats you with others by design.
- **Port-day friendliness is not a port-week commitment.** Sharing a taxi to Palancar on Monday doesn't obligate you to anyone's New Orleans plan. Pairings form and re-form all week; that's the design.
- **A group this size produces a few real connections, not a crowd of them.** A hosted solo week tends to yield two or three friendships that outlast the trip and a circle of friendly faces. That's a good outcome — don't measure the week against "everyone became best friends."

Section 10 — Solo Cruising Considerations

The Gem suits solo travelers well: a mid-size, easy-to-learn ship, O'Sheehan's open at all hours for a low-pressure solo meal, Teppanyaki's communal tables, and a hosted group that stays findable. The features that matter:

- **O'Sheehan's** — the always-open pub is the solo cruiser's anchor: a burger and a game on at 11 PM, no table-for-one question.
- **Teppanyaki** — communal seating means you dine with others whether or not you booked alone.
- **The spa thermal suite and the pool deck** — solo-friendly by nature; nobody's counting who came with whom.

For first-time solo cruisers:

- Tina runs **welcoming, low-pressure** group cruises. Show up when you want, skip when you want.
- The Day 1 group meetup is the easiest way to find your people in the first 24 hours.
- The **Solo Cruising Practical Guide** covers the broader rhythm and the small social moves that make a solo week feel right.

Solo cruising stories. Tina has written extensively on solo cruising — her **solo cruising hub** collects the practical, the emotional, and the social rhythms across multiple sailings. Worth reading whether before, during, or after this trip.

If you're sailing this one to mark a transition

Some readers of this pack are solo because of where life has put them — a recent loss, a marriage that ended, a long stretch of caregiving that finally has a quiet week in it. This is a gentle itinerary for that kind of trip: unhurried sea days, one warm island, and two slow days in a city built for wandering. And there's something quietly fitting about arriving in New Orleans on Ash Wednesday — the day the celebration ends and Lent's

reflective season begins. Tina's broader writing on the **solo hub** — particularly **In the Wake of Grief** — names this directly; this pack won't repeat what she's already said well. If that's why you booked, the resources are there to read at your pace.

Solo safety — cabin and onboard

Solo cruising is overwhelmingly safe — cruise ships are among the most surveilled travel environments anywhere, with CCTV in common areas, 24-hour security, controlled deck access, and crew trained in emergency response. The Cruise Vessel Security and Safety Act (US federal law since 2010) mandates camera coverage and reporting obligations. None of this makes risk zero, but the baseline is high. A few habits still make sense:

Your cabin door. Use the deadbolt and privacy latch at night. Some solo cruisers add a portable door wedge — under \$10, takes no space, and calming for anyone who sleeps uneasily in an unfamiliar room.

Ashore in New Orleans — normal city sense. The French Quarter is busy and well-policed by day and into the evening, but it *is* a city: stick to populated, well-lit streets at night, keep a hand on your bag in a crowd, and use rideshare after dark rather than walking long distances alone. The day after Mardi Gras is calmer than Carnival week, which helps.

Share your itinerary before sailing. Send the day-by-day to one trusted person ashore, with your cabin number once assigned and your insurance policy number. The family handoff card in **Section 6** is built for exactly that.

Friendliness is not obligation. A good conversation at the Spinnaker Lounge is not an invitation to dinner; a shared dinner is not an invitation to a port day. You set the pace, and on a hosted solo cruise declining doesn't fracture anything — see **Section 9**.

If something feels off, Guest Services and the 24-hour security desk respond fast. Most solo cruisers go a lifetime without needing this; the option exists if you do.

Section 11 — First Cruise Notes

If this is your first cruise of any kind, the **first-cruise guide** is the deeper read. A few foundational notes:

- **The cabin is small.** Even a balcony cabin is smaller than a budget hotel room. You're not living in it; you're sleeping in it. The ship is your living room.
- **You can't get lost.** Every elevator lobby has a deck map, and any crew member can point you. On a 15-deck ship you'll have the layout within a day.
- **You don't need to book everything ahead.** Most days unfold with significant unplanned time. That's by design — and the New Orleans overnight especially rewards leaving room to wander.
- **Tipping is built in.** Beyond the daily service charge you don't need to tip every interaction; a few dollars to a great bartender or steward at the end of the week is appreciated, not expected.
- **Don't try to do everything.** Two days in New Orleans is enough to do what matters if you don't try to do all of it. Pick a few things and let the rest be next time.

The thing nobody tells first-timers: the best moments are usually unplanned — the slow Mississippi sailaway you almost slept through, the second-line brass you stumble on turning a corner, the conversation at O'Sheehan's at midnight. The **Cruising Duck tradition** is the one piece of cruise culture worth knowing in advance — bring or hide a few rubber ducks if you want a friendly, accidental social ritual.

Leave room for that.

Closing

This pack is the calm read on one specific week — yours.

Soli Deo Gloria. All work on this project is offered as a gift to God. The site that produced it is independent — no affiliate links, no commissions, no upsells. If it helped you, that's the whole point.

Safe sailing.

Last reviewed | 2026-07-06 |

How facts here are checked | Every ship spec, price, date, contact number, and currency claim in this pack is checked against a primary or authoritative source — NCL's own published FAQ (service charge), Wikipedia and Meyer Werft/registry records for ship specs and christening, the ship's own In the Wake profile for its venue list, the New Orleans tourism calendar for the Mardi Gras / Ash Wednesday dates, the U.S. Consulate in Mérida for Mexico contacts, and operator pages where excursions are quoted. Sources for each claim are kept in this pack's factcheck sidecar. If a number can't be sourced, it isn't asserted here. Tina's communications about her group's rhythm are quoted as hers. |

Accessibility | This pack and the site that produced it follow WCAG 2.1 AA. The Emergency Contacts section is offline-capable via the companion app so a trusted contact ashore can keep the family handoff card available without an internet connection. See also the **disability-at-sea guide**. |

Sources | Ship: **Norwegian Gem**; scale via **Ship Size Atlas**, fleet context via **ships hub**. Ports: **Tampa, Cozumel, New Orleans**. Host + agent: **Tina Maulsby, Maulsby Travel Co.**. Onboard venues: **Grand Pacific, Garden Café, O'Sheehan's, Cagney's Steakhouse, Le Bistro, La Cucina, Teppanyaki, Moderno Churrascaria**. Articles: **stateroom-sanity-check, is-drink-package-worth-it, cruise-tipping-2026, caribbean-cruise-trends-2026, cruise-cabin-organization, cruise-tech-photography-guide, cruise-seasickness-what-works, cruise-embarkation-day-what-to-expect, cruise-duck-tradition**. Tools: **drink-calculator, cruise-budget-calculator, cruise-tipping-calculator, port-day-planner, port-tracker, ship-tracker, ship-size-atlas**. Reference pages: **solo cruising hub, Solo Cruising Practical Guide, In the Wake of Grief, first-cruise, countdown, packing-lists, internet-at-sea, disability-at-sea, affiliate-disclosure**. Original research: ncl.com onboard-service-charge FAQ, en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Norwegian_Gem, mardigrasneworleans.com (2027 dates), the Norwegian Gem In the Wake profile. |